

people. They gathered detailed information which shows the horrifying extent to which these people have been subjected to serious human rights abuses. This report provides an overview of the delegations' findings together with information on human rights abuses obtained subsequently and on the context in which these abuses are taking place. It concludes with recommendations for immediate action to be taken by governments, armed political groups and the international community. It should be read in conjunction with other Amnesty International documents, including: *Guinea: Refugees must not be forced to choose between death in Sierra Leone or death in Guinea*, 5 April 2001 (AI Index: AFR 29/003/2001); *Liberia: War in Lofa County does not justify killing, torture and abduction*, 1 May 2001 (AI Index: AFR 34/003/2001); *Guinea and Sierra Leone border: fighting continues to endanger civilian lives*, 4 May 2001 (AI Index: AFR 51/004/2001). Amnesty International will also publish a further report including detailed case studies.

Guinea

During the last decade, Guinea was a place of safety and refuge for hundreds of thousands of Liberians and Sierra Leoneans who had fled protracted armed conflicts in their own countries. Since September 2000 it has become a place of violence, death and fear.

In March 2001 Amnesty International delegates interviewed refugees, mostly Sierra Leoneans, who had fled within Guinea after attacks by armed political groups on the Guinean towns of Pamélap, Macenta, Katkama, Guéckédou and Nongoa, and on villages and refugee camps. Those interviewed referred most frequently to the RUF; however, Guinean and Liberian armed political groups are also reported to be active in southern Guinea. In areas bordering Sierra Leone - the southeastern Forest region, especially an area known as the Parrot's Beak, and the southwestern Forécariah region - refugee camps have been attacked by armed political groups, in particular the RUF. Although the exact number is not known, hundreds of Sierra Leonean refugees have been killed, beaten, raped and abducted during attacks. There are also reports that the RUF has forcibly recruited refugees in these camps to fight against Guinean security forces. Many have fled from one camp to another, in attempts to escape the violence and, in desperation, at least 20,000 Sierra Leoneans have crossed the border overland into RUF-held areas of Sierra Leone.

Guinean civilians have suffered similar grave abuses during attacks by armed political groups. Towns and villages in southern Guinea have been occupied or have been the sites of protracted fighting between these groups and Guinean security forces. This has forced tens of thousands of Guineans, perhaps as many as 300,000 at one point, to flee their homes in search of safety. Most remain internally displaced within Guinea and in need of protection and humanitarian assistance.

In a radio broadcast on 9 September 2000, Guinean President Lansana Conté accused refugees of supporting or assisting armed political groups from their own countries. This came two days before the conviction and sentencing of political opposition leader and prisoner of conscience Alpha Condé, imprisoned since December 1998 and accused by President Conté of having instigated fighting on the borders. Amnesty International and others, including human rights defenders in Guinea, protested at his unfair trial and conviction. Amnesty International welcomes the release of Alpha Condé on 18 May 2001 following a presidential pardon, after serving half of a five-year prison sentence.

After President Conté's radio broadcast, many Guinean civilians turned against refugees and harassed and intimidated them. Refugee camps, after being attacked and abandoned, have often been burned by local civilians so as to prevent their occupants returning. Liberian and Sierra Leonean refugees have been singled out for killings, arbitrary arrests, torture and ill-treatment by the Guinean security forces. At military checkpoints and elsewhere, Guinean security forces have obstructed, intimidated and threatened refugees as they tried to move away from border areas or return to their own country. In one incident in early October 2000, a helicopter gun-ship flew low over a refugee camp in Kalia, Forécariah region, and fired artillery close to the camp, which resulted in civilian deaths and injuries; this appeared to be a deliberate attempt by the Guinean security forces to terrorize refugees and force them to flee the camp.

Refugees from Sierra Leone have been arbitrarily detained, often in large groups, and accused of being members or supporters of the RUF. Amnesty International delegates interviewed many refugees who were arrested solely because they bore marks or scarring on their bodies which were assumed by the Guinean security forces to be indications of involvement with the RUF. In most cases described to Amnesty International, individuals were able to secure their release after several hours or days by paying a bribe to the security forces. In other cases, however, those arrested were reported to have died in detention, apparently as a result of torture or ill-treatment, or their fate remained unknown.

The Office of the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) has stated that it is caring for over 80,000 Liberian refugees in Guinea, mostly around Nzérékoré in the southeast, near the Liberian border. By June 2001 UNHCR was reportedly expecting to have relocated at least 25,000 of them away from the border areas to safer areas of the country, but this has not yet taken place. Waiting for relocation, these refugees have neither planted and stored food, nor prepared their homes for the rainy season which has now begun. Little information is available about Liberian refugees in the area around Macenta, also in the southeast near the Liberian border. There has been little or no international presence there since the killing of a UNHCR official in September 2000. However, there have been reports that an unknown number of refugees are still in the area in need of assistance and protection including from recruitment by Liberian armed political groups. On 9 May 2001 a non-governmental organization Refugees International, following a visit to southern Guinea, described the conditions for Liberian refugees there as "unacceptable". It warned that the refugees are in urgent need of materials for shelters, food rations and protection from the fighting spilling over from northern Liberia.

Furthermore, hundreds of Liberian refugees fleeing human rights abuses and fighting in northern Liberia are reported to be prevented from crossing into Guinea by Guinean security forces at the border. It appears that only those who have the means to pay border guards are able to enter the country. UNHCR has raised concerns about this, both publicly and with the Guinean authorities, but the border is reported to remain closed.

In Guinea, the location of refugee camps close to the borders with Liberia and Sierra Leone has attracted cross-border raids by armed political groups. Concerns that the camps have provided bases for these groups have been raised by humanitarian agencies over the years. However, many refugees and the Guinean authorities were reportedly opposed to relocating camps in Guinea further from the borders. Some efforts were made in 1999 to relocate refugees, but only since September 2000 has relocation been considered urgent. By early June 2001 UNHCR had completed the voluntary relocation of around 57,000 refugees from the Parrot's

Beak area away from the border. Amnesty International welcomes this relocation. There is still an urgent need, however, to relocate Liberian refugees in the areas around Macenta and Nzérékoré to safe areas.

Liberia

Human rights abuses in Liberia have dramatically increased since 1999 when Liberian armed political groups based in Guinea, believed to be backed by Guinean security forces, began incursions into Lofa County, northern Liberia. Diplomatic relations between Liberia and neighbouring Guinea and Sierra Leone progressively deteriorated. The Amnesty International delegation that visited Liberia in February 2001 found that scores of civilians suspected of supporting or collaborating with dissidents have been arrested, tortured and extrajudicially executed by Liberian security forces. It appears that women and girls have been raped by both government forces and armed political groups, although the identity of those responsible has often been difficult to establish. Civilians are reported to have been abducted by armed political groups. Some have been killed while trying to escape abduction. In an attempt to prevent sensitive information getting out of Liberia, especially about human rights abuses, critics and opponents of the government have frequently been labelled as "dissidents" by the authorities and have increasingly been subjected to verbal and physical attacks by the security forces.

Since February 2001 fighting in Lofa County has further intensified and Amnesty International has received reports of increasing human rights abuses against civilians, including internally displaced people. On 13 June 2001 the World Food Programme estimated the number of recently displaced people from Lofa Country to be around 40,000. Many people fleeing their homes have reportedly been turned back at checkpoints by the security forces on suspicion that dissidents were among them. Humanitarian agencies have frequently been denied access to internally displaced people or intimidated and threatened by the security forces while providing assistance or transferring displaced people. Camps for the internally displaced have been established in locations which many observers in Liberia believe to be too close to the areas affected by fighting. The strong presence in the camps of security forces responsible for human rights violations, such as the Anti-Terrorist Unit, has been a cause of concern for many civilians and humanitarian agencies.

The Liberian security forces have reportedly continued to recruit child soldiers, including from among internally displaced people. There have also been reports of people being subjected to beatings or torture by government forces when they have resisted recruitment. During 2000 the RUF reportedly carried out recruitment in camps for Sierra Leonean refugees in Liberia, including of former child soldiers who had previously been recruited by the RUF in Sierra Leone. Senior Liberian government officials were reportedly seen accompanying RUF personnel during the recruitment in refugee camps.

In some cases, Liberian refugees repatriated from Guinea have been arrested and tortured by Liberian security forces. On 14 June 2000 at least seven Liberian refugees from the Mandingo ethnic group, who had been repatriated from Guinea by UNHCR, were arrested by Liberian security forces at the Ganta border post, Nimba County. They were detained and tortured for two weeks and at least one of them reportedly died in custody.